



WARMING UP:
Antony (left)
with Serdyukov

PLAYING THE RUSSIAN CARD

Defence ties with Russia move to the next level with a series of joint ventures, but it is a political balancing act which India has timed in a manner to seemingly distance itself from the US

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

With the UPA Government under increasing pressure over the nuclear deal, the biggest beneficiary could well be a resurgent Russia. Last week, Defence Minister A.K. Antony reached Moscow to sign a deal with his Russian counterpart Anatoly Serdyukov for the joint-development of a fifth generation fighter aircraft. "The agreement will give a new quality to our defence ties with Russia," Antony said. "It marks the start of the development of state-of-the-art, new-technology weapon systems," he added. One can expect more such platitudes when Prime Minister Manmohan Singh visits Russia next month. The two sides are to sign up for the joint development of

a Multirole Transport Aircraft—a 100-seater military transport aircraft with a capacity to carry 15 tonne of cargo. These ventures, say defence officials, mark an attempt to move from mere off-the-shelf purchases—India buys arms worth \$1 billion (Rs 4,000 crore) from Russia every year—to genuine joint development.

Yet, the timing of the \$10 billion project to develop a futuristic fighter aircraft, the largest joint venture between the two nations, raises the question whether it is more to allay the Left parties' fears that the UPA is leaning militarily towards the US. "The timing of the agreement seems more politically driven, like a Russian antibiotic to cure the viral

fever of the nuclear deal," says Air Vice-Marshal (retired) Kapil Kak of the Centre for Air Power Studies (CAPS).

Antony said India's ties with the US would not be at the cost of its "special relationship" with Russia, leading analysts to suspect a balancing act by the Government. The UPA has quietly shelved a proposal for a Logistics Support Agreement (LSA) with the US pending before the Cabinet Committee on Security since June. The LSA simply states that Indian warships and military aircraft can be refuelled and



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